

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Cooks and Kitchen Staff English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Line cooks, prep cooks, kitchen assistants, and dish-team colleagues.

All situations, quantities, recipes, times, and product details are fictional English practice, not culinary certification or food-safety instruction. This course does not teach cooking temperatures, chemical use, equipment repair, or allergen-control procedures. Follow workplace training and the responsible kitchen lead's decisions. It concerns kitchen communication rather than hospitality management.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

all day

Kitchen shorthand for the combined quantity currently ordered across the relevant open tickets.

allergen declaration

Information identifying allergens present in a product's ingredients.

batch

A quantity of food prepared as one planned production unit.

bottleneck

A stage where limited capacity delays other kitchen work.

carryover

Food or work remaining from an earlier period, with any permitted use subject to workplace requirements.

closing checklist

A list of tasks to confirm at the end of a kitchen shift.

cross-contact concern

A question about unintended allergen transfer during handling or preparation.

delivery note

A supplier's document listing items and quantities sent with a delivery.

dietary modification

A requested change to a dish related to a diner's stated dietary need or choice.

dish rack

A frame that holds dishes or utensils during handling in the dish area.

eighty-six

Kitchen slang indicating an item is unavailable; usage should be confirmed locally.

equipment fault

A reported problem with how a kitchen device is functioning.

expediter

The person coordinating tickets, dish readiness, and pickups between kitchen and service staff.

lot code

A label identifier linking a product to a production batch or lot.

mise en place

Ingredients and equipment organized for a kitchen's planned work.

on the fly

Kitchen shorthand requesting an item urgently; it does not remove required checks.

out of service

A status indicating equipment is not available for use.

par level

A workplace's planned stock quantity used as a replenishment reference.

pass

The kitchen area where completed dishes are checked and collected for service.

pickup

The collection of dishes at the pass for delivery to a table or customer.

plating

Arranging the prepared components of a dish on its serving plate.

portion count

The number of servings currently counted for a particular item.

prep list

A list of ingredients or components to prepare before or during service.

recipe specification

The current documented ingredients and requirements for a particular dish.

short delivery

A delivery containing less than the quantity expected.

sign-off

A recorded acknowledgment that a specified check or task has been completed or approved.

substitute item

An alternative dish or component offered in place of an unavailable one.

substitution

A replacement ingredient or item requested instead of the standard one.

ticket

A kitchen's written or electronic record of a food order.

traceability

The ability to connect a food item to its source and relevant identifying records.

waste log

A record of food discarded and the stated reason or quantity.

yield

The usable amount a recipe or ingredient is expected to produce.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask what the number counts

Does ___ mean portions or ___?

Which recipe version applies to ___?

So the required yield is ___, not ___.

Numbers need units. A recipe's yield and a container count describe different things; familiarity with yesterday's sheet isn't confirmation for today.

Word combinations in this lesson

check the required yield: confirm the usable amount needed

work from the prep list: use the current task list

prepare one batch: make the specified production quantity

clarify the unit: distinguish portions, containers, and weights

Report what was actually counted

The note lists ___; I counted ___.

We haven't established whether ___.

Could you reconcile ___ before ___?

Use 'lists' for the document and 'counted' for the observation. A possible explanation is not a verified delivery.

Word combinations in this lesson

count the delivered cases: check the actual number received

flag a missing label: report absent identifying information

match the delivery note: compare physical items with the supplier's list

report a short delivery: state the difference between expected and received quantities

Make corrections audible

Is this an addition or a correction to ___?

That's ___ total on ticket ___.

One with ___ instead of ___; the others ___.

A revised ticket may replace an earlier instruction. 'Instead of' signals replacement; 'as well as' signals addition.

Word combinations in this lesson

call the full ticket number: identify the exact order aloud

read back the modification: repeat the requested change

count orders all day: total the relevant open orders

separate a correction from an addition: distinguish a changed order from an extra item

State partial readiness precisely

___ of ___ dishes are ___.

The remaining ___ need approximately ___.

Please wait for ___ before calling ___.

'Two are plated' doesn't mean 'four are ready.' Name the remaining items and the reference point for an estimate.

Word combinations in this lesson

call a pickup: announce which completed order can be collected

synchronize the table: coordinate dishes intended to leave together

give a station update: state current progress on assigned dishes

keep the ticket visible: preserve the order reference during coordination

Offer a named alternative with a condition

We have ___ left for ___ requested.

We can offer ___ if ___.

Please confirm which seats accept ___.

An available substitute is not an accepted substitute. Use 'if' to connect the offer to the diner's decision.

Word combinations in this lesson

run low on a component: have little of a needed item remaining

update the available count: report the current usable allocation

offer an alternative side: propose a different accompaniment for approval

confirm guest acceptance: check that the diner agreed to the offered change

Name the missing check

Omitting ___ does not establish ___.

The new information is ___.

We still need the lead to check ___.

A change to one ingredient doesn't establish the entire dish's suitability. Keep reported facts and the pending review explicit.

Word combinations in this lesson

check the specification: consult the current recipe information

refer the suitability question: ask the designated lead to assess the request

keep the order pending: leave the decision unresolved until the needed check occurs

distinguish omission from suitability: do not equate removing one component with resolving every dietary concern

Describe a fault without diagnosing it

The ___ at ___ is ___.

I observed ___; the cause is unknown.

Could you confirm an available ___?

An observation supports a report, not a technical diagnosis. Name the device, location, effect, and requested help.

Word combinations in this lesson

report the observed fault: describe what happened without diagnosing it

request a replacement unit: ask for another suitable piece of equipment

prioritize a dish request: identify which needed tableware should be discussed first

give the location: say exactly where the problem or shortage is

Separate done, recorded, and approved

___ is complete; ___ awaits review.

Can you take ___ and confirm ___?

I'll retain responsibility for ___.

A written entry can await review. A task assigned to someone isn't complete until they perform it and report back.

Word combinations in this lesson

hand over an open task: transfer unfinished work with a named receiver

reconcile the portion count: check that records and counted amounts agree

record the stated reason: use the observed or confirmed explanation

leave a check unsigned: do not claim completion before verification

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Clarifying a prep list

The prep list says 'soup: 24' without a unit. Yesterday's sheet used portions; the storeroom label uses containers. The lead intended 24 portions from the current recipe, not 24 containers. No batch has started.

The soup line says twenty-four, but it doesn't specify portions or containers. Before I start a batch, could you confirm the unit and the recipe version? Yesterday's sheet used portions, while the storage label counts containers. I'll repeat the required yield once we know which quantity today's prep list means.

Try it again: The cook finds a second sheet dated Friday. Identify which sheet governs today's task.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Reporting deliveries and stock discrepancies

The delivery note lists six cases of tomatoes; four are physically present. The driver says two may be on another trolley but has not checked. The receiving lead must resolve the record. Report the observed count without accusing the supplier or recording six as received.

I can count four tomato cases here, while the delivery note lists six. Two may be on the other trolley, but that hasn't been checked. Please keep the received quantity unconfirmed until the receiving lead reconciles the count. I'll show them the four cases and the delivery note together.

Try it again: The driver finds one more case. Update the observed count to five without declaring the delivery complete.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Reading tickets and modifications

Ticket 41 originally has two tarts. A new slip says 'three tarts, revised 41.' The expediter confirms this replaces the old quantity, so the total is three, not five. One tart has salad instead of potatoes. Confirm quantity and substitution.

Does the revised ticket replace the two-tart quantity on ticket forty-one, or add three more? If it replaces it, I have three tarts total, with salad instead of potatoes on one. Please confirm that modification applies to only one tart so I don't change all three plates.

Try it again: Someone calls 'three more' after the correction. Repair the quantity before work continues.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Coordinating the pass

Ticket 28 has four mains. Two are plated; two are still at the cook's station. The cook estimates four more minutes for the remaining pair. The expeditor asks whether the whole table is ready. Report partial progress and the current estimate.

Ticket twenty-eight is not complete yet. Two mains are plated, and the other two are still at my station. My current estimate for that pair is four more minutes. Please don't call the full pickup yet. I'll update you when the remaining dishes are ready for your check at the pass.

Try it again: The runner points to the two plated dishes and assumes the whole ticket can leave.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Communicating a shortage and an alternative

Three portions of potatoes remain unallocated, but a new ticket requests five. Rice is available as a proposed alternative side; the server must check whether two diners accept it. The cook cannot silently substitute. Agree who obtains the diners' decision.

We have three unallocated potato portions for this five-meal ticket. Rice is available as an alternative for two meals, but the guests haven't agreed to that change. Could you ask which two diners, if any, would accept rice? I'll keep the original request clear until you bring back their choices.

Try it again: Only one diner accepts rice. Restate the remaining shortage and ask the lead about another option.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Checking dietary modifications

Ticket 17 says 'no cheese.' The server then reports that the diner has a milk allergy. The sauce specification has not been checked. The cook must not treat omission of cheese as confirmation that the dish is suitable; the lead can review it with the server.

Removing the cheese answers the original modifier, but it doesn't establish that the dish meets this guest's milk-allergy concern. We haven't checked the current sauce specification or the handling question. Please keep ticket seventeen pending while the kitchen lead reviews those details and the server explains what remains unconfirmed to the diner.

Try it again: The guest says another restaurant makes it without cheese. Explain why that doesn't verify this recipe.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Reporting equipment and dish-station needs

The display on scale B at the pastry prep bench keeps going blank. No cause is known. The cook has stopped using it and needs the lead to arrange review and confirm whether scale A is available. Do not offer repair instructions.

Scale B at the pastry prep bench keeps losing its display. I've stopped using it, and I don't know the cause. Could you arrange a review and confirm whether scale A is available for this assignment? The pastry prep quantity remains unverified, so I need a confirmed alternative before reporting that task complete.

Try it again: The colleague asks whether the fault will be fixed before service. Keep the completion time unconfirmed.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Closing and handing over unfinished work

At shift change, the garnish count is complete at twelve portions, the waste-log entry for three damaged tarts awaits the lead's review, and the closing shelf check has not been performed. Ask the incoming cook to accept the shelf check without treating the waste review as complete.

The garnish count is complete: twelve portions. The entry for three damaged tarts is in the waste log, but the lead hasn't reviewed it yet. The closing shelf check hasn't been done. Can you take that check and confirm when it's complete? I'll follow up with the lead about the separate waste-log review.

Try it again: The lead is unavailable now. Keep review pending rather than treating silence as sign-off.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: Cooks

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/food-preparation-and-serving/cooks.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Cooks, Restaurant

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/35-2014.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Cooks and Kitchen Staff English

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Lesson 01: Clarifying a prep list

Original fictional case: The prep list says 'soup: 24' without a unit. Yesterday's sheet used portions; the storeroom label uses containers. The lead intended 24 portions from the current recipe, not 24 containers. No batch has started.

Language workshop: Ask what the number counts

Communication goal: Clarify quantities before interpreting a kitchen shorthand.

Language guidance: Numbers need units. A recipe's yield and a container count describe different things; familiarity with yesterday's sheet isn't confirmation for today.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Does ___ mean portions or ___? / Which recipe version applies to ___? / So the required yield is ___, not ___.

Vocabulary: mise en place: Ingredients and equipment organized for a kitchen's planned work. / prep list: A list of ingredients or components to prepare before or during service. / yield: The usable amount a recipe or ingredient is expected to produce. / batch: A quantity of food prepared as one planned production unit.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Lead cook: confirm 24 portions using Monday's recipe; container numbers are storage counts.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The cook finds a second sheet dated Friday. Identify which sheet governs today's task.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The soup line says twenty-four, but it doesn't specify portions or containers. Before I start a batch, could you confirm the unit and the recipe version? Yesterday's sheet used portions, while the storage label counts containers. I'll repeat the required yield once we know which quantity today's prep list means.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Test recall and transfer

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Review with supported choices and speaking

1. Ask me to close my notes. Prepare six four-choice questions: two vocabulary gaps, one grammar contrast, one confirmed-versus-unknown distinction, one choice of reply, and one transfer to a clearly labelled fictional variation.
2. Show only the first question. Use a short role-labelled exchange or a concrete scenario, four plausible choices A-D, and exactly one defensible answer. Stop and wait.
3. After each answer explain all options, offer one hint for a retry if needed, and invite me to say the completed exchange aloud. Only then move on. Do not request an original written response.
4. Track whether I answered independently or with a hint, not a certified proficiency score. Do not assess pronunciation from typed text. Replace ambiguous questions and accept valid spoken alternatives.
5. Give a compact review card with three four-choice recall items and a separate answer section. Summarize two specific successes and two points to revisit. Do not claim to remember or schedule future sessions.

END PROMPT